Teacher: There is. I shall come to that later. Let us stand up and wish her first.

Students: Happy birthday, Tamil.

Tamilini: Thank you all.

Teacher: Tamil, Is Chennai your home town?

Tamilini: No ma'm. My home town is Kadavur near Karur.

Teacher: Good. Do you have the habit of visiting your home town?

Tamilini: Yes ma'm. Every summer I visit my home town.

Teacher: Excellent! Can you tell me the difference between Kadavur and Chennai?

Tamilini: Kadavur is a village. Chennai is a city.

Teacher: Excellent!

Teacher: Can you tell what were the earliest planned cities of ancient India?

Students: Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro, ma'm.

Teacher: Yes. Very good children. Today we are going to study about the ancient towns of Tamilagam. They are Poompuhar, Madurai, Kanchi. Shall we start?

Students: Ok ma'm.

Teacher: See we have started today's lesson with Tamilini's birthday.

Students: Yes mam.



Mesopotamian civilisation is the earliest civilisation in the world. It is 6500 years old.

Teacher: Like Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro in ancient India, there were famous towns in ancient Tamilagam too. Madurai, Kanchi and Poompuhar are prominent among them.

Tamil literature, accounts of foreign travellers and archaeological finds provide us information about the ancient towns of Tamilagam.

Poompuhar

Poompuhar is one of the oldest towns in ancient Tamilagam. This is the place where well known characters of Silapathikaram, Kovalan and Kannagi lived. It was also a port town along the Bay of Bengal. The ports were established for facilitating maritime trade. Even in times past, countries began to export their surplus products and import the scarce commodities by sea. Poompuhar is one such historic port that emerged in the wake of increasing maritime trade. It is a coastal town near the present-day Mayiladuthurai and is located where the river Cauvery drains into the sea.

Poompuhar Port

Poompuhar was also known by names such as Puhar and Kaveripoompattinam. It served as the port of the early Chola kingdom. One of the popular Sangam Literature, *Pattinappaalai* and Tamil epics, *Silappathikaram* and *Manimegalai*, have references to the brisk sea-borne trade that took place in the port city, Puhar.

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Silappathikaram, in particular, speaks about the greatness of Poompuhar.